ODISHA

Doing the Sambalpuri Samba

SRK got all of India shimmying with his *Lungi Dance*, but it's **Naveen Patnaik**'s Sambalpuri lungi that's stirring up a coastal storm in Odisha. In a video posted on his Instagram account, the 77-year-old CM took an unusual sartorial route to canvass for votes for the simultaneous Lok Sabha and assembly elections. Usually in a patrician bubble aloof from the hoi polloi, here he was clad in the lungi distinct to this tribal-flavoured western zone and holding aloft a 'jodi sankha' (twin conches)—conch is the Biju Janata Dal symbol—looking almost like a king flywhisking himself with a beatific smile. The outgoing BJP minister and Sambalpur candidate **Dharmendra Pradhan** wasn't smiling, though. At a rally in Jharsuguda on April 23, he flung a jibe at a 'gumasta' (agent) for not getting his elderly ward properly dressed. No names, but the dig was clearly aimed at the Tamilian in the Odishi *khechudi*: **V.K. Pandian**, ex-IAS man widely seen to be running the show for Naveenbabu. The BJD, in turn, accused Pradhan of insulting Odisha's culture by lampooning the Sambalpuri lungi and dyeing it in communal hues. Many even wore the humble attire in solidarity. Odisha will have the simultaneous polls on May 13, May 20, May 25 and June 1.



GUJARAT

OF PATELS, PA



MAHARASHTRA

Astral Psephology, Anyone?

Neither pundit nor punter may wager a bet on the LS polls right now, so maybe it's time for soothsayers to step in? They aren't lacking for an invitation. The Maharashtra Andhashraddha Nirmulan Samiti (MANS), founded by the murdered rationalist and anti-superstition crusader Narendra Dabholkar, has put out a challenge for astrologers: foretell the poll results accurately and win Rs 21 lakh! There's even a chance for spread betting: predict the number of votes Nitin Gadkari, Rahul Gandhi, Mahua Moitra, K.K. Shailaja and